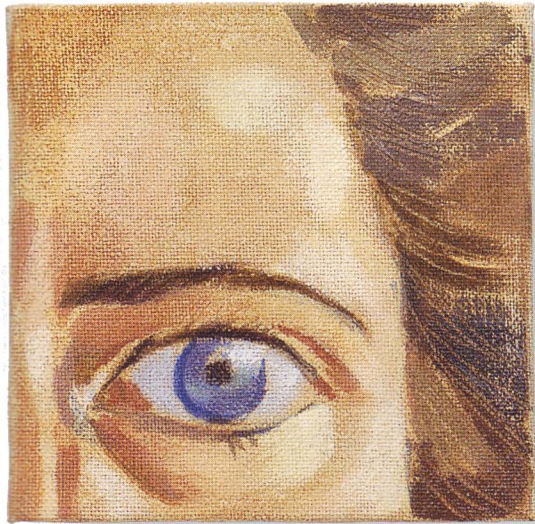
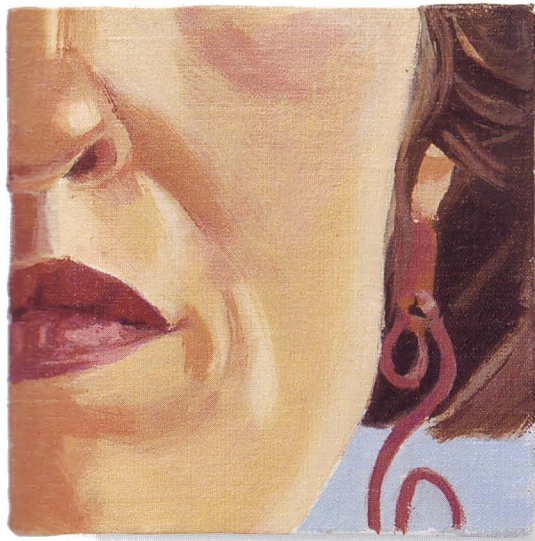


The qualities of oil paint

One characteristic of oil paint that differentiates it from other media is its richness and depth of color. This is because the pigments are ground in a drying oil that has a relatively high refractive index (the amount of light it reflects and absorbs). Chalk that otherwise appears opaque white becomes practically transparent when it is mixed with linseed oil. Pigments vary in their refractive index, which



A rough colored canvas gives these dry strokes of color more texture



This fine canvas allows individual strokes of color to be blended smoothly together

to a large extent dictates whether they appear transparent, semi-opaque, or opaque in oil. When compared to other media, oil paints are the most successful at exploiting the different qualities of opacity and transparency. Over a pure white ground, for example, a thin layer of a transparent oil color has a saturation and depth that is difficult to achieve in any other medium.

Creating different effects with oil paint

The four studies shown here demonstrate some of the characteristic effects of oil color, used in different ways on a variety of surfaces. The smooth board on the top left-hand side provides a hard, untextured surface on which the brushstrokes remain clearly visible and unblended. A thin, warm transparent glaze, painted over the various colors, deepens the tone of the portrait and makes the face appear more cohesive. The bottom panel on the left is a rough surface on which thick paint has been applied as impasted brushstrokes. The uneven texture of this surface automatically affects each brushstroke, and as a result, the style is much bolder and chunkier. The top right-hand section is a rough canvas that has been prepared first with a single tone of one color, applied over the whole surface and then left to dry. This colored canvas is visible between areas of paint on the face and hair, so that the canvas and paint appear to be integrated as one surface. Paint has been applied with a dry brush technique that picks up the ridges of the rough canvas, while scratches (known as sgraffito) on the hair have been made with the end of a brush handle. The bottom right section shows a smooth canvas over which paint has been carefully blended. Different tones and colors have been painted as areas of light and shade, and then blended together to create a smooth transition between colors.

